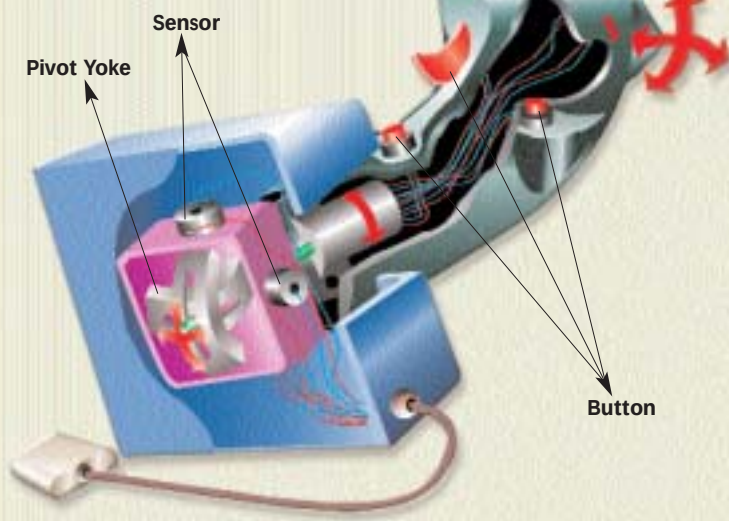


Under the bonnet of a Joystick



Buying Tips: Joysticks

■ Joysticks are ideal for playing flight simulators and space combat games, so if you are a great fan of these don't settle for a game pad.

■ Joysticks are available in many flavours, but ideally they should have a hat-switch, a throttle control and at least six programmable buttons.

■ Before you buy a joystick, check out the ball joint to ensure its durability. Do this by holding the broomstick and moving it sideways—if the motion is jerky or sticky,

don't buy it.

■ Before you zero in on a joystick, hold it to see whether your palm and fingers feel comfortable, and your fingers reach the buttons without extending them.

■ Always buy a stick with a heavy base, since a light base will skid or trip when the stick is moved with force.

■ If you are an avid fan of flight simulators, go for a stick that has three axes. This will give you better control over the rudder of a flying unit.

AD

Future of Input Devices

Futuristic Keyboards

If you're using a standard QWERTY keyboard—and most of us do—your keyboard design is over a century old. Keyboard design has stagnated over the last few years, and users do not have much choice as far as design goes. However, some vendors have launched products that are wacky, to say the least, and ergonomic as well.

For instance, SafeType Inc has launched a keyboard that they claim has been designed according to scientific biomechanical principles and virtually eliminates the high-stress postures that contribute to Repetitive Stress Injury. This device looks like a standard QWERTY keyboard that's been broken up into

three equal pieces.

The two outermost pieces are placed vertically, with keys on the outside, and a couple of mirrors placed alongside. The horizontal middle piece has the number keys.



A 'user-to-computer interface tool' called DataHand looks extremely futuristic and aims to minimise movement, thus drastically reducing the amount of effort needed for typing and pointing. The DataHand System consists of two interconnected hand units that can effectively assume the role of keyboard and mouse. The palm rests on rubber supports, and the fingers are placed on the keys just beyond. The thumb is placed in